# False Show Attribution Caused by Generic Character Names in Cast Lists

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**Abstract**, Several spoiler summaries about the film Fight Club were attributed to the series How I Met Your Mother and blurred under that title. All samples contained the word “narrator”, which is also a character name in the series’ TVmaze cast list. This report documents the inferred cause, the filter that removes generic character words from the match terms and the tests that were run.

*Index Terms, false positives, entity matching, TVmaze, text matching, Chrome extension.*

## I. Introduction

SpoilFree decides which tracked title a text is about by matching the title and the character names of the show, which are fetched from the TVmaze cast endpoint when a title is added [1]. A text that matches a title is sent to the classifier and may be blurred.

## II. Problem Description

The developer supplied eight search-result passages about Fight Club that were blurred and reported as How I Met Your Mother. Each passage contained the word “narrator” and none named the series. The cause is inferred from this common word and from the cast-list design: a single-word character name that is also an ordinary English word matches unrelated text. The cast list itself was not inspected, so the inference is consistent with all samples but not directly confirmed.

## III. Implemented Solution

Match terms are now built in three parts. The title and the TVmaze show name are always used. A character’s full name, such as a first and last name, is kept. A single word from a character name is kept only if it has at least five letters and is not in a list of generic words such as narrator, mother, father, doctor, officer, nurse, young, older and future. For movies, only the title is used, because the TVmaze result for a movie name is usually an unrelated show whose characters would add noise. Terms shorter than four characters after normalisation are dropped by the matcher [2].

## IV. Verification

A Node test used a fake How I Met Your Mother cast containing Ted Mosby, Barney Stinson, Narrator, Marshall Eriksen, Lily Aldrin and Older Ted. After the change the Fight Club sentence no longer matched the series, the sentence “Barney Stinson and Marshall Eriksen went to the bar” still matched it and a Fight Club sentence matched the film. Behaviour on live pages was not reproduced in the authoring environment.

## V. Conclusion

Cast-derived terms improve recall for texts that omit the title but are risky when they are common words. Names of two or more words and a stop list keep most of the recall. First names shorter than five letters no longer match on their own, which is a known trade-off.

## References

[1] TVmaze, “TVmaze API.” Accessed: Oct. 28, 2026. [Online]. Available: https://www.tvmaze.com/api

[2] Mozilla, “RegExp,” MDN Web Docs. Accessed: Oct. 28, 2026. [Online]. Available: https://developer.mozilla.org/en-US/docs/Web/JavaScript/Reference/Global_Objects/RegExp